ALASS: Assessment of Language in Adults using Self-reported Skills

Revised 31-item version · Free to use under the Creative Commons Attribution 4.0 licence (CC BY 4.0)

About this questionnaire. The ALASS asks adults to rate their own language skills, as they recall them in early childhood and as they are now. It is a research and screening questionnaire, **not a diagnostic test**: it has no clinical cut-off scores, and a low score is not evidence of a language disorder. Anyone concerned about their language should speak to a speech and language therapist.

Part A. Childhood (before age six)

Do you recall having one of these difficulties as a child BEFORE BEING SIX YEARS OLD?

This might be something that your parents, relatives or teachers might have mentioned to you, or something that you just felt you struggled with.

Please rate the following items on a scale of 1 to 10, where 10 means 'I'm very good' and 1 means 'I'm not very good'.

	I'm not very good = 1 · I'm very good = 10	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10
A1	Producing sounds (phonics)	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
A2	Producing single words	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
A3	Producing sentences	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
A4	Speaking with friends	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
A5	Speaking with your teacher	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
A6	Reading out loud	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
A7	Spelling	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
A8	Blending sounds to make words, e.g. 'c-oa-t' makes 'coat'	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
A9	Understanding what I have read	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
A10	Understanding English sounds (phonics)	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
A11	Understanding verbal instructions	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
A12	Writing a sentence	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
A13	Writing a story	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○

Part B. Adulthood (now)

Do you recall having one of these difficulties as AN ADULT (now)?

This might be something that your parents, relatives or teachers might have mentioned to you, or something that you just felt you struggled with.

Please rate the following items on a scale of 1 to 10, where 10 means 'I'm very good' and 1 means 'I'm not very good'.

	I'm not very good = 1 · I'm very good = 10	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10
B1	Producing sentences	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
B2	Speaking with friends	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
B3	Speaking with your doctor	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
B4	Talking on the telephone with someone that you know well	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
B5	Talking on the telephone with someone that you don't know well	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
B6	Speaking in public	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
B7	Speaking within a group	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
B8	Reading out loud	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
B9	Spelling	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
B10	Understanding something that I have read	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
B11	Understanding English sounds (phonics)	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
B12	Understanding the content of a lecture	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
B13	Understanding verbal instructions	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
B14	Writing a long piece of text	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
B15	Writing a story	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
B16	Writing a letter or email	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
B17	Writing an academic essay	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
B18	Taking notes in a lecture/meeting	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	○

Scoring

Every item is rated from 1 (“I'm not very good”) to 10 (“I'm very good”). No item is reverse-scored. Each score is the **mean** of the items answered, so all scores range from 1 to 10 and higher scores mean better self-reported skills.

Score	Items	Number of items
Childhood Language (CL)	A1–A13	13
Language Performance (LP)	B1, B2, B4, B8–B18	14
Social Use of Language (SUL)	B3, B5, B6, B7	4
ALASS total	All 31 items	31

Interpretation. There are no validated cut-off scores. Scores can be compared between groups or used as continuous measures in research. In a sample of 130 UK university students, the means were CL 8.10 (SD 1.87), LP 8.56 (SD 1.60), SUL 7.39 (SD 2.02) and total 8.22 (SD 1.58); these describe one student sample and are not norms.

Administration notes

- The wording above is exactly as administered online (Qualtrics) to the 2025 and 2026 validation cohorts. The second sentence of the Part B instructions was carried over from Part A and is kept for comparability.
- Present Part A before Part B. Items were not randomised.
- Responses were requested but not forced; scores use the mean of the items answered.

How to cite

- Joyce, H., & Aguado-Orea, J. (2022). The divergent nature of language performance and social use of language: An online scale for the Assessment of Language in Adults using Self-reported Skills (ALASS). *International Journal of Developmental Science*, 16(1–2), 27–42. https://doi.org/10.3233/DEV-210316

Licence: CC BY 4.0 (https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/4.0/). You may copy, translate and adapt the ALASS, including for commercial use, provided you credit the original work and indicate any changes.